NaijaABSA Annotation Guidelines

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These guidelines explain how to label Nigerian app reviews for the NaijaABSA research dataset. Read them fully before you start, and keep them open while you work.

1. Purpose

You will read Google Play reviews of Nigerian apps across ten sectors (telecoms, banking and fintech, electricity, e-commerce, ride-hailing, food delivery, education, travel, government services, and pay-TV and streaming) and record **what each writer gives an opinion about** and **whether that opinion is positive, negative or neutral**. Many reviews are in Nigerian Pidgin or mix English with Pidgin, Igbo, Yoruba or Hausa.

Your labels become the correct answers that AI models learn from and are tested against. Careful, consistent labels matter more than speed.

What you need: a phone or laptop with internet, access to your own Google Sheet (shared with you by the researcher), and about 30–60 seconds per review.

2. How to annotate one review

Work on the **Annotate** tab. Fill only the yellow cells; never change the green example rows or the review text.

1. **Read the whole review** in column C, once for meaning and once for detail.
2. **Decide whether it gives any opinion** about the product or service. If not, write `no opinion` in **Notes** and move on (Section 6).
3. **Find each aspect**: each thing the writer judges (Section 3). For up to three aspects:
   - type the aspect's **exact words** from the review in *Aspect 1*, *2* or *3*;
   - choose its **Category** from the dropdown (Section 4);
   - choose its **Polarity** from the dropdown (Section 5).
4. **If the writer judges something they never name in words**, fill *Implied aspect category* and *Implied aspect polarity* instead.
5. **Choose yes or no** for *Sarcastic?* and *Cultural reference?* (Section 5).
6. **Choose the Language** (Section 6).
7. **Use Notes** for anything unclear, so the researcher can review it. Never leave a review half done.

3. Aspects

An **aspect** is the specific thing the writer has an opinion about: a feature, a service, a part of the experience. *Transfer*, *data*, *network*, *customer care*, *token*, *delivery* and *app* are typical aspects.

Rules for explicit aspects (named in words)

- Copy the words **exactly as written**, including Pidgin spelling (*netwok*, *custmer care*).
- Mark the **shortest phrase** that names it: *battery*, not *the battery of this phone*; *customer care*, not *their customer care people*.
- If the same aspect is mentioned twice, mark it **once**.
- If the writer judges the app or service as a whole (*"This app sweet"*, *"Worst bank"*), the aspect is that word (*app*, *bank*) and the category is **product overall**.
- Do **not** mark words that carry no opinion: in *"I used the app to buy data and it failed"*, the opinion is about the **data** purchase failing, not about *app*.
- If there are more than three aspects, mark the **three with the clearest opinion**, and write "more aspects" in Notes.

Implied aspects (not named in words)

Sometimes the writer clearly judges something without naming it. *"Na so una dey do every time, abeg do better"* on an electricity app is a complaint about **power supply**, but no word says so. Leave the Aspect columns empty and fill *Implied aspect category* and *Implied aspect polarity*. Only do this when you are confident what is being judged; if you are guessing, write your thought in Notes instead.

4. Categories

The same **12 categories** are used for every sector. Choose the **one category** that best describes each aspect. If two seem to fit, pick the more specific one (*payments and transactions* rather than *app performance* for a failed transfer). The review's sector is already recorded in the **Domain** column, so the category only describes *what kind of thing* is being judged.

Category	Use it for	Example
product overall	The app, company or service as a whole	*"Best bank app for Naija"*

Category	Use it for	Example
core service	The main thing the company provides: network and data, electricity supply, the ride, the flight or bus trip, TV signal and channels, lessons, ID registration	*"Network no dey for my area"*, *"No light for two days"*
price and fees	How much things cost: prices, fares, tariffs, bills, bank charges, deductions	*"Dem dey remove money anyhow"*, *"Bolt fare too cost"*
payments and transactions	Paying, sending, receiving or buying: transfers, top-ups, tokens, subscriptions; failed, pending or missing transactions	*"Transfer pending since yesterday"*, *"Token no load for my meter"*
refunds and reversals	Getting money back after a failure or cancellation	*"Dem never reverse my money"*
delivery and timing	Speed, waiting and arrival: delivery time, pickup time, delays, cancellations	*"Food come late and cold"*, *"Driver cancel three times"*
staff and drivers	Behaviour of people providing the service: drivers, riders, agents, sellers, cabin crew	*"The driver rude well well"*
product and content quality	Quality of what was bought or received: goods, food, TV programmes, lesson content	*"The phone dem send na fake"*, *"Food no sweet"*
customer service	Support staff, call centre, chat replies, complaint handling	*"Custmer care no dey pick call"*
app performance	Crashes, slowness, bugs, updates, design, ease of use	*"App dey hang since update"*
login and account	Logging in, OTP, PIN, verification, registration, blocked accounts	*"OTP no dey come"*
trust and safety	Scams, fraud, fake listings, unsafe rides, feeling cheated	*"Na scammers full this app"*

Quick guide by sector

Sector	Common aspects and their category
Telecoms	network, data, airtime → *core service*; data price → *price and fees*; recharge → *payments and transactions*
Banking and fintech	transfer, payment → *payments and transactions*; charges → *price and fees*; OTP, BVN → *login and account*
Electricity	light, power supply → *core service*; token, units → *payments and transactions*; bill, estimated billing → *price and fees*
E-commerce	delivery → *delivery and timing*; goods → *product and content quality*; sellers, scams → *trust and safety*
Ride-hailing	the ride → *core service*; driver → *staff and drivers*; fare → *price and fees*; pickup, cancellation → *delivery and timing*
Food delivery	food → *product and content quality*; rider → *staff and drivers*; arrival time → *delivery and timing*
Education	lessons, videos → *core service* or *product and content quality*; subscription → *price and fees*
Travel	flight, bus trip → *core service*; delay → *delivery and timing*; booking → *payments and transactions*
Government services	registration, ID, slip → *core service*; verification → *login and account*
Pay-TV and streaming	signal, channels → *core service*; programmes → *product and content quality*; subscription price → *price and fees*

Rule of thumb: if the writer paid and did not get what they paid for, choose *payments and transactions*. If the service itself was poor (bad signal, no light, a bad ride), choose *core service*. If none fits, choose the closest one and write a better name in Notes. The researcher will review these after the first batch.

5. Polarity, sarcasm and cultural references

Polarity is the writer's feeling about that one aspect:

- **positive**: pleased, praising, recommending (*"Transfer dey enter sharp sharp"*)
- **negative**: complaining, angry, disappointed (*"Transfer don hang since morning"*)
- **neutral**: an aspect is mentioned with no clear feeling, or a plain question or request (*"How I go take change my PIN?"*)

Judge each aspect **separately**. One review can be positive about the app and negative about charges. Ignore the star rating; judge only the words.

Sarcastic? = yes when the words say one thing but the writer means the opposite. *"Thank you MTN for the data wey finish in one hour"* sounds grateful but is a complaint. For sarcastic reviews, the polarity is the **intended** meaning, so this one is **negative**. Laughing emojis (😂) and words like *"well done"* or *"thank you o"* at a failure are common signals.

Cultural reference? = yes when someone without Nigerian knowledge would misunderstand the review. Examples: *NEPA* or *"light"* meaning electricity, *"una"* addressing the company, references to local events, places, public figures or slang such as *"japa"* or *"wahala"*. If any Nigerian adult would understand it but a foreign reader might not, choose **yes**.

6. Language and reviews with no opinion

Language describes the whole review:

- **English**: standard or Nigerian English with no Pidgin grammar (*"The app keeps crashing after the update"*)
- **Pidgin**: mainly Nigerian Pidgin (*"Dis app no dey work at all"*)
- **Code-switched**: a clear mix of English, Pidgin, Igbo, Yoruba or Hausa (*"The app is fine sha, but customer care no dey respond, biko"*). Write the languages involved in Notes, for example "English + Igbo".

A single Pidgin word in an otherwise English sentence (*"The app is good sha"*) counts as **Code-switched**.

No opinion. Write `no opinion` in Notes and leave the other columns empty when the review:

- only asks a question or describes an action with no judgement;
- is spam, an advert or a random message;
- is not about the app or its service at all;
- is too unclear to understand.

Still choose the **Language** for these reviews.

7. Worked examples

These examples were written to illustrate the rules; they are not real reviews.

Review	Domain	Aspects (category, polarity)	Sarcastic?	Cultural ref.?	Language
This app sweet well well, but the transfer no dey go at all	banking	*app* (product overall, positive); *transfer* (payments and transactions, negative)	no	no	Pidgin
Thank you MTN for the data wey finish in one hour 😂	telecoms	*data* (core service, negative)	yes	no	Pidgin
I don buy token since morning, nothing show for my meter	electricity	*token* (payments and transactions, negative)	no	no	Pidgin
Na so una dey do every time, abeg do better	electricity	implied: core service, negative	no	yes	Pidgin
Delivery was fast and the rider polite, but the shoe na fake	e-commerce	*Delivery* (delivery and timing, positive); *rider* (staff and drivers, positive); *shoe* (product and content quality, negative)	no	no	Code-switched
Driver cancel three times, I come waka go office	ride-hailing	*Driver* (delivery and timing, negative)	no	no	Pidgin
Food reach fast but e don cold, the rice no sweet at all	food delivery	*Food* (delivery and timing, positive); *rice* (product and content quality, negative)	no	no	Pidgin
Well done DStv, una increase price again, signal still dey go when rain fall 👏	pay-TV	*price* (price and fees, negative); *signal* (core service, negative)	yes	no	Pidgin
Flight delay five hours, nobody talk anything	travel	*Flight* (delivery and timing, negative)	no	no	Code-switched
How I go take reset my PIN?	banking	none: write `no opinion`	no	no	Pidgin
Dem dey remove ₦50 every time I transfer, wetin be this?	banking	implied: price and fees, negative	no	no	Pidgin
Since this app come, NEPA wahala don reduce for my house	electricity	*app* (product overall, positive)	no	yes	Pidgin

Hard cases

- *"Dem dey remove ₦50…"* has no single aspect word for the charge, so use the **implied** columns.
- In *"Delivery was fast and the rider polite"*, *Delivery* and *rider* are separate aspects in different categories; mark both.
- In *"Driver cancel three times"*, the complaint is about the cancellations (timing), not the driver's behaviour, so the category is *delivery and timing*.
- In the last example, *NEPA wahala* explains **why** the app is good; the writer is not judging NEPA, so NEPA is not an aspect.

8. Rules of conduct, privacy and checklist

Work independently. Do not discuss reviews with the other annotator, and do not look at their sheet. Disagreements between you are useful: they show where the rules need to be clearer.

Do not use AI tools (ChatGPT, Gemini or similar) to label reviews. The study needs human judgement.

Privacy. Reviews are public, but treat them carefully. Do not copy, share or post them anywhere. If a review contains a person's name, phone number or other personal detail, write "personal detail" in Notes; do not edit the review text.

Breaks. Label in sessions of 30–45 minutes. Accuracy drops when you are tired. You may skip any review you find offensive; write "skipped" in Notes.

Questions. Write your question in Notes and carry on. Contact the researcher, Juliet Chinenye Duru, for anything urgent.

Quick checklist for every review

- [ ] I read the whole review.
- [ ] Each aspect is copied with its exact words, or I used the implied columns.
- [ ] Each aspect has one category and one polarity.
- [ ] For sarcasm, I chose the **intended** polarity.
- [ ] Sarcastic?, Cultural reference? and Language are filled.
- [ ] Anything unclear is explained in Notes.